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CAGED LION Former PM Imran Khan (far left) at an Islamabad court in May 2023; PTI supporters at a protest in Karachi, Feb. 11

petrol, have soared. The International Monetary Fund (IMF) has projected Pakistan's external debt to touch $130.85 billion in 2023-24, up from $123.57 billion in 2022-23. The country will still need some harsh measures—which will no doubt be unpopular on the streets—for its economy to recover. There is also consensus that the country will have to enter into another restrictive IMF support programme almost immediately. A new round of privatisation of state-owned white elephants, such as the national airline PIA and Pakistan Steel Mills, endorsed by the military-controlled Special Investment Facilitation Council (SIFC), is also on the cards, which will undoubtedly cause labour resentment. The flailing economy and its recovery will then be the biggest test for the Sharifs.

NAWAZ'S CONUNDRUM

Even though the PML-N aggressively campaigned on slogans that Sharif would be prime minister, in reality, many had anticipated that the elder Sharif was actually trying to create political space for his 50-year-old daughter Maryam, aside from seeking vindication for his being 'wrongly' removed from power in 2017. He may have achieved both the goals, but a lot will now depend on the Punjab chief minister-elect Maryam Nawaz delivering. In particular, the PML-N is facing the anger of the younger, upwardly ambitious population in Punjab, which has often spilled out as resentment against the traditional parties for shutting them out of power. The PML-N's choice of candidates indicates that the Sharif family is still its reference point in terms of who it feels it can trust. It remains to be seen whether Maryam can change this perception and attract a younger demographic towards the party. Her own style of dealing with people—apparently brooking very little dissent—may also need to change for that to happen.

Meanwhile, the PML-N is trying to come to terms with the fact that, despite being in a position to form governments at the Centre and in Punjab, it has suffered serious setbacks in the central Punjab belt that it considers to be its stronghold. Some of its big names lost to unknowns from the PTI. Former interior minister and PML-N Punjab president Rana Sanaullah, who also lost his seat, probably had the most circumspect analysis of what happened. "The main issue in this election was the inflation," he told a TV channel. "People are hurting, from the rise in electricity and gas prices and petrol prices, having to sell off their household goods to pay bills. And no matter what we said [in the electioneering], it could not take away the pain of these three things. Plus, the last-minute triple convictions of [Imran Khan] just before the election probably backfired and got him a sympathy wave, even though that had to do with the courts and nothing to do with us."

BILAWAL'S CALCULUS

With the PPP deciding to give outside support to the PML-N at the federal level, senior leaders within the PML-N have expressed resentment over the sense that the